Pieni l'animo — damaged historical English witness

Pius X · 1906-07-28 · English

PREACHING AND POPULAR ACTION.

Pius X., Pope, to His Venerable Brethren the Archbishops AND Bishops of Italy.

Venerable Brethren, Health and the Apostolic Benediction:

WITH our soul full of fear for the strict account we shall have to give one day to the Prince of Pastors, Jesus Christ, with regard to the flock entrusted to us by Him, we pass our days in continual anxiety to preserve the faithful, as far as possible, from the most pernicious evils by which human society IS at present afflicted. Hence we regard as addressed to us the word of the prophet: "Cry, lift up thy voice like a trumpet" (Is. Iviii., i) ; and we fail not, now by word of mouth and now by letter, to warn, beseech, reprehend, exciting, above all, the zeal of our brethren in

the episcopate so that each of them may exercise the most eager vigilance in the portion of the fold over which the Holy Spirit has set him.

The cause which induces us to raise our voice anew is of the gravest moment. It is a question demanding all the attention of your mind and all the energy of your pastoral office against a dis- order from which the most baleful effects are already experienced; and if it is not removed with a strong hand in the most radical manner, consequences still more fatal will be felt in the progress of years. We have, in fact, before us letters from not a few of you, Venerable Brethren — letters full of sadness and tears, deploring the spirit of insubordination and independence displayed here and there amidst the clergy. All too surely a poisonous atmosphere largely corrupts men's minds in our days, and the deadly effects are those which the Apostle St. Jude formerly described: "These men in truth defile the flesh and despise dominion and blaspheme majesty" (Jude i., 8) ; that is, besides the most degrading corruption of man- ners there is an open contempt for authority and for those who exercise it. But that this spirit should penetrate in any wise into the sanctuary and infect those to whom the words of Ecclesiasticus ought most fittingly to be applied: "Their generation obedience and love" (iii., i) — this is what overwhelms us with grief. And it is especially amongst young priests that this unhappy spirit is doing damage, new and reprehensible theories with regard to the very nature of obedience spreading themselves amongst them. And, what is more serious, as if to acquire new recruits for the growing troop of rebels, such maxims are being propagated more or less secretly amongst the young who in the enclosures of the seminaries prepare themselves for the priesthood.

Wherefore we consider it a duty. Venerable Brethren, to make an appeal to your conscience in order that, laying aside all hesitation, you should, with vigorous minds and not less vigorous firmness, exert yourselves to destroy this evil seed, fruitful in destructive consequences. Always remember that the Holy Spirit has placed you to rule. Remember the command of St. Paul to Titus: "Re- buke with all authority. Let no man despise thee" (ii., 15). Require rigorously from priests and clerics that obedience which is absolutely obligatory on all the faithful, but constitutes the chief part of the sacred duty of priests.

To prevent effectually the multiplication of these quarrelsome souls, it will be well. Venerable Brethren, ever to bear in mind the sublime warning of the Apostle to Timothy: "Impose not hands lightly upon any man" (I. Timothy v., 22). It is in truth the facility of admitting to sacred orders that naturally opens the way to a mul-

tiplication of people in the sanctuary who do not increase joy. We know that there are towns and dioceses where, far from there being cause to lament a scarcity of clergy, the number of priests is much greater than the faithful need. Ah, Venerable Brethren, what ground can there be for imposing hands so frequently? If the scarcity of the clergy cannot be a sufficient reason for haste in a matter of such gravity, where the clergy are more numerous than the requirements demand nothing excuses from the most delicate caution and the greatest rigor in the selection of those who are lo receive the honor of the priesthood. Nor can the urgency of the aspirants lessen the fault of a too ready facility. The priesthood, instituted by Jesus Christ for the eternal salvation of souls, is surely not a human profession or office to which every one who desires, for whatever reason, has a right freely to devote himself. Let the Bishops then promote to sacred orders not according to the desires and pretexts of those who aspire to the priesthood, but as the Council of Trent prescribes, according to the necessities of the dioceses ; and in promoting this they can only select those who are really fit, dis- missing

those who have inclinations contrary to the priestly vocation, the chief of which inclinations are a disregard for discipline and the pride of mind that begets it.

In order that youth who display qualities suitable to the sacred ministry may not be wanting we wish. Venerable Brethren, to insist with greater earnestness on what we have already pointed out several times, namely, the obligation that rests upon you — a most serious one before God — to watch over and further with the utmost solicitude the right conduct of the seminaries. Your priests will be as you have trained them. Most important is the letter on this subject which was addressed to you on the 8th December, 1902, by our most prudent predecessor, as a testament from his long Pontificate. To that we desire to add nothing new ; we shall merely remind you of the rules it lays down; and we strongly recommend the immediate execution of our orders, published through the Sacred Congregation of Bishops and Regulars, on the concentration of the seminaries, especially for the study of philosophy and theology, in order to secure in this way the great advantage resulting from the separation of the greater seminaries from the smaller ones and the other ad- vantage, not less great, attaching to the necessary instruction of the clergy.

Let the seminaries be jealously maintained in the spirit that prop- erly belongs to them, and let them remain exclusively destined to prepare youth not for civil careers, but for the exalted mission of ministers of Christ. Let philosophy and theology and the kindred sciences, especially Sacred Scripture, be studied in accordance with

the Pontifical directions and with the teaching of St. Thomas recom- mended by our venerated predecessor so often, and by us in the ApostoHc Letter of the 23d January, 1904. Let the Bishops, then, exercise the most scrupulous vigilance over the masters in their doctrines, recalling to a sense of duty those who run after certain dangerous novelties and removing, without any regard, from the office of teaching all who do not profit by the warnings received. Frequentation of the universities is not to be permitted to young clerics except for very grave reasons and with the greatest precau- tions on the part of the Bishops. Seminary students are to be abso- lutely forbidden to take part in any way in outside agitations, and we accordingly prohibit them from reading papers and periodicals except, in the case of the latter, some of sound principles that the Bishop may deem suitable for study by the students. Let discipline be ever maintained with increasing vigor and vigilance. Lastly, there must be in every seminary the spiritual director, a man of more than ordinary prudence and experienced in the ways of Christian perfection, who is, with indefatigable zeal, to train the youth in that solid piety which is the first foundation of the spiritual life. These rules. Venerable Brethren, where conscientiously and firmly followed, will afiford you a sure guarantee of seeing growing up around you a clergy that will be your joy and your crown.

Otherwise the disorder of insubordination and independence, which we now lament, will go a good deal further in some of the young clergy and cause much greater harm, because there are not wanting those who are so much a prey to this reprobate spirit that, abusing the sacred office of preaching, they openly act as its promoters and apostles to the ruin and scandal of the faithful.

Our predecessor on the 31st July, 1894, through the Sacred Con- gregation of Bishops and Regulars, drew the attention of the Ordina- the Pharaohs who had been removed slept in peace until our own regulations laid down in this Pontifical document, laying an obliga- tion in this respect on the consciences of the Bishops, so that the words of the Prophet Nahum may never be applicable to any of them: "Thy shepherds have slumbered" (iii., 18). No one can have powder to preach ''unless he first be approved of in life, knowledge and morals " (Cone. Trid. Sess. V., cap. 2, "De Refor."). Priests from other dioceses should not be admitted to preach without letters of testimony from their own Bishop. Let the subject of their sermons be that indicated by the Divine Redeemer when He said : "Preach the Gospel" (Mark xvi., 15), "teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you" (Mark xxviii., 20). Or, according to the comment of the Council of Trent, "announcing to them the vices they should avoid and the virtues they should follow

in order that they may escape eternal punishment and attain heavenly glory" (Log. cit.). Then, let arguments better suited to journalistic campaigning and to academic halls than to the pulpit be banished altogether from that holy place ; let moral preaching be preferred to sermons that are, to say the least, fruitless ; and let the preacher speak "not in the persuasive words of human wisdom, but in showing of the spirit and power" (I. Cor. ii., 4). Wherefore the principal source from which preaching will derive its strength should be the Sacred Scriptures, understood not according to the private judgment of minds most frequently blinded by passions, but according to the traditions of the Church and the interpretations of the holy fathers and the Councils.

You should judge, Venerable Brethren, conformably to these rules of those to whom you entrust the ministry of the divine word. And whenever you find that any of them, more concerned for their own interests than for those of Jesus Christ, more anxious for worldly applause than for the good of souls, depart from them, warn and correct them, and if that is not sufficient, remove them inexorably from an office for which they prove themselves completely unworthy. Vigilance and severity of this kind should be all the more readily employed by you because the ministry of preaching belongs specially to you and is a chief part of the episcopal office ; and whoever outside your ranks exercises it does so in your name and in your place. Whence it follows that you are always responsible before God for the manner in which the bread of the divine word is dispensed to the faithful. To relieve ourselves from all responsibility, we point out to all Ordinaries and enjoin upon them the duty of discontinuing or suspending, after charitable warnings, even during a course of sermons, any preacher, secular or regular, who does not entirely obey the injunctions contained in the above mentioned instruction of the Congregation of Bishops and Regulars. It were better that the faithful should content themselves with simple homilies and explanations of the catechisms given by their parish priests than to be present at sermons that do more harm than good.

Another field in which, amongst the young clergy, too much scope and too great a stimulus is found for maintaining and advocating exemption from every bond of legitimate authority is that of the so-called popular Christian action. Not indeed. Venerable Brethren, because this action is in itself reprehensible, or from its nature con- duces to tie contempt of authority; but because many, misunder- standing its character, have voluntarily abandoned the rules which were laid down for its promotion by our predecessor of immortal memory.

We refer, as you are aware, to the Instructions on the Popular

Christian Action, which went forth by order of Leo XIII. from the Sacred Congregation of Extraordinary Ecclesiastical Affairs on the 27th January, 1902, and which were transmitted to each of you to be carried out in your respective dioceses. These instructions we, on our part, maintain, and in the fullness of our power we renew each and all of the regulations, as we also confirm and renew all the orders issued by ourselves for the occasion in the "Motu Proprio" of the i8th December, 1903, "De Populari Actione Christiana Moderanda," and in the circular letter of our beloved son, the Car- dinal Secretary of State, dated the 28th July, 1904.

As to the foundation and direction of newspapers and periodicals, the clergy must faithfully observe what is prescribed in Article 42 of the Apostolic Constitution "Officiorum :" (i) "Clergymen are to be prohibited from directing (moderanda) newspapers or periodicals without the previous consent of the Ordinaries." So, also, without the previous consent of the Ordinary none of the clergy can publish any writing of the kind, whether on a religious or moral subject, or of a moral character, or of a character merely technical. Prior to the foundation of circles and societies the rules and statutes must be examined and approved of by the Ordinary. No priest or cleric can give conferences (lectures) on Popular Christian Action or any other subject without the permission of the Ordinary of the place. Any language that may inspire aversion to the higher classes is and must be regarded as altogether contrary to the true spirit of Christian charity. And in like manner are to be condemned in Catholic publi- cations any terms which, breathing of unhealthy novelty, deride the piety of the faithful and point to nezv orientations of the Christian life, new directions of the Church, nezv aspirations of the modern soul, a new social vocation of the clergy, a new Christian civilization and similar things. Whilst it is praiseworthy for the priests, especially those of them who are young, to go to the people, they must nevertheless proceed in this matter with due obedience to authority and to the commands of the ecclesiastical superiors. And in devoting themselves, with the subordination already mentioned, to Popular Christian Action, it must be their noble duty "to rescue the children of the people from ignorance of spiritual and eternal things, and to induce them with active kindness to live honestly and virtu- ously ; to strengthen the adults in the faith, removing contrary influ- ences, and to fortify them in the practice of the Christian life; to promote amongst the Catholic laity those institutions that are truly efficacious for the moral and material improvement of the masses of the people; to uphold, above all, the principles of evangelical justice and charity which equitably apply tp all the rights and dutiies of civil society. . . . But let them always bear in mind that even in

the midst of the people the priest ought to preserve inviolate his august character as a minister of God, being placed at the head of his brethren animarum causa (S. Greg. M. Regul. Past. Pars, ii., c. vii.) ; any mode of devoting himself to the people to the detriment of the priestly dignity and to the prejudice

of ecclesiastical duties and discipline can only be reproved" (Ep. Encycl., 8th December, 1902).

For the rest. Venerable Brethren, to raise an effectual barrier against this extravagance of idea and this extension of the spirit of independence we, by our authority, absolutely prohibit all clerics and priests henceforward to give their names to any society that does not depend on the Bishops. In a more special manner and in par- ticular we prohibit them under penalty, for the clerics, of inability to take holy orders and, for the priests, of suspension ipso facto a divinis, from becoming members of the National Democratic League, whose programme was issued from Roma-Torette on the 20th Octo- ber, 1905, and whose statutes were printed in the same year, without the name of the author, by the Provisional Committee at Bologna.

Such are the directions which the solicitude of the Apostolic Office demanded from us, having regard to the present condition of the clergy in Italy and the importance of the subject. It only remains for us to excite your zeal anew. Venerable Brethren, in order that these arrangements and regulations be quickly and fully carried out in your dioceses. Prevent the evil where fortunately it does not yet show itself; suppress it speedily where it is springing up, and where unhappily it is already ripe extirpate it with an energetic and resolute hand. Laying this matter on your consciences we implore for you from God the spirit of prudence and the necessary firmness. And to this end we impart to you, with all our heart, the Apostolic Benediction.

Given at St. Peter's, Rome, on the 28th July, 1906, the third year of our Pontificate.

Pius X., Pope.

Source. Open the source witness. Historical English wording is public domain in the United States; later translations, host wrappers and project-created apparatus have separate status. Historical English translation in The American Catholic Quarterly Review 31 (1906), pp. 744–750. Translator unrecorded. Damaged historical printing: p. 747, annual raw OCR physical line 40130, visibly substitutes an unrelated line about Pharaohs between the body fragments Ordina- and regulations. The expected substantive continuation is missing. Preserve the entire surviving printed English extent and the intrusive line; no missing words are invented. This witness is outside complete-act counts. OCR recognition errors, punctuation, broken words and historical source order remain. Full selected OCR extents and outer boundaries were read; no complete word-for-word print-image collation or corrected text is claimed. Revision: 2026-10-30T02:56:48Z.

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